

Softening

Practice Five · Nervous System Regulation · Full Script · 5 minutes (audio) / full script below

The audio version of this practice uses a shorter, condensed reading of this script. This is the complete text, with all four phases, for reading alongside the audio or using on its own.

Opening · Breath and Light · 3 minutes

Find a comfortable position. This practice works with spasticity. The aim isn't to fight the tension — it's to soften gradually into a more rested state. Best practised when you're in a calmer phase, not during severe spasms.

You can hear these words. Your body is being held by whatever you're resting on. Your breath is moving without being asked. And as you notice these things, something in you can begin to settle.

Take a slow breath in through your nose, and let it out through your mouth — slowly, with the out-breath longer than the in-breath. The longer out-breath quietens the nervous system. In. Out, longer. In. Out, longer still. Settle into this gentle pattern.

Bring attention to the top of your head. The crown. Just above it, a soft point of light — felt, not pictured. Each in-breath, brighter. Each long out-breath, the light spreads gently downward — soft, slow, unforced. And wherever the light touches, that place can rest a little more.

Phase One · The Ideal Being · 3 minutes

A figure begins to form in front of you. Whoever this figure is for you. This figure has a body that knows how to rest. Their muscles hold what they need to hold and release what they don't. Their body is undefended — no fight, no grip, no anticipation of attack.

The figure isn't trying to relax — they're simply not holding anything they don't need to hold. The figure moves toward you. Steps into you. And gradually, perhaps without noticing the exact breath it happens on, you're no longer watching. You are them. Their softness is yours. Whatever your body's pattern is right now, the figure's calm settles into it. Not fighting the spasticity. Not pushing it away. Just adding softness alongside it.

Phase Two · The Pathway · 3 minutes

Spasticity comes from a particular pattern in the nervous system. When the spinal cord is injured, signals from the brain that normally tell the muscles to stay calm have trouble getting through. The work isn't to fight that firing. It's to add another signal — a signal of safety.

Begin at the brain. The vagus nerve — long, wandering — carries calming signals from your brain down through your throat, chest, and belly. Even after spinal cord injury, the vagus nerve is intact. Each long exhale activates this calming system. Each long exhale tells your nervous system: you are safe. You can rest.

Now bring awareness to wherever your spasticity is most active today. Forcing an area to relax tends to make spasticity worse, so the work here is gentler. Bring warmth there. The light from above. The breath from inside. Soft, friendly attention. With each long out-breath, send a quiet signal: you are safe. You can soften. You don't need to grip right now.

Closing · Breath and Light · 3 minutes

Return to the breath. Long out-breaths. The vagus nerve doing its quiet work. The light still moving slowly downward. The signals of safety you sent are real.

Spasticity often gets worse with stress and rushing, and gentler with calm and warmth. This practice is a way of nudging the nervous system toward the calmer state, on purpose. You can return many times during the day — not as a full practice, just as a few long out-breaths.

At night, drifting toward sleep, your nervous system naturally moves toward this calm state. A few long breaths deepens that shift. When you first wake, your body is in its softest state — the most precious window for this work.

Take one more slow breath in. Let it out, longer. Notice the room. The light is yours. The pathway of rest is yours. The practice continues. Thank you.

This practice is part of the Guided Imagery Programme at livingbeyondsci.com, free to use. It is not a substitute for medical advice, and does not claim to reverse or cure spinal cord injury. If any part of it increases discomfort, stop and try a different practice.